

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, cloudy, afternoon snow, sleet, high 36. **Tonight**, sleet and rain early, then all rain, low 33. **Tomorrow**, cloudy, breezy, rain, some thunder, high 46. Weather map, Page B10.

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HIROKO MASUIKE/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Better Than a Box of Chocolates
Valentine’s Day meant “joyful chaos” for courthouse weddings. Above, Jessica Goulart and Gilan Salehi in Manhattan. Page A21.

No. 2 in Trump’s Justice Dept. Aided Dismissal Push for Adams

This article is by Michael S. Schmidt, William K. Rashbaum, Maggie Haberman and Jonah E. Bromwich.

President Trump had just taken office when lawyers for Mayor Eric Adams of New York went to the White House with an extraordinary request: They formally asked in a letter that the new president pardon the mayor in a federal corruption case that had yet to go to trial.

Just a week later, one of Mr. Trump’s top political appointees at the Justice Department called Mr. Adams’s lawyer, saying he wanted to talk about potentially dismissing the case.

What followed was a rapid series of exchanges between the lawyers and Mr. Trump’s administration that exploded this week into a confrontation between top Justice Department officials in Washington and New York prosecutors.

Agency’s Collaboration Shattered Norms of Enforcing the Law

On Monday, the acting No. 2 official at the Justice Department sent a memo ordering prosecutors to dismiss the charges against the mayor. By Thursday, the acting U.S. attorney in Manhattan, Danielle Sassoon, had resigned in protest over what she described as a quid pro quo between the Trump administration and the mayor of New York City. Five officials overseeing the Justice Department’s public integrity

Continued on Page A12

NEXT STEP Federal prosecutors formally asked a judge to drop the mayor’s charges. PAGE A13

Mayor Still Faces Political Peril Even if Trial Has Been Avoided

By EMMA G. FITZSIMMONS

When the Justice Department ordered federal prosecutors on Monday to drop the corruption case against Mayor Eric Adams of New York City, he hoped that it would save his political career and allow him to better focus on governing the nation’s largest city.

Instead, the mayor is in even more peril, his political future is still in question and New Yorkers’ trust in him is precipitously waning. In just the last 48 hours, the top Democrat in the House, nearly every major member of the city’s elected leadership, civic leaders, pastors and even staunch mayoral allies have credibly argued that he let President Trump gain effective sway over the most important City Hall in America.

Calls for his resignation have escalated. Pressure is mounting on Gov. Kathy Hochul to use her power to remove the mayor.

Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, citing Mr. Trump’s “leverage over Adams,” said that if the mayor “won’t resign, he must be removed.” Representative Nydia Velázquez said Mr. Adams must step down because the city could not be “led by someone under Trump’s thumb and willing to sell out New Yorkers.”

The calls also came from Ms. Hochul’s lieutenant governor, Antonio Delgado, and the State Senate’s No. 2 Democrat, Michael Ganimaris, and from the mayor’s primary challengers. And all of that preceded the Justice Department’s formal four-page motion, filed on Friday, to drop the charges against the mayor.

Continued on Page A14

Calls for His Removal or Resignation Keep Growing Louder

VANCE IMplores EUROPE TO ACCEPT EXTREME PARTIES

GERMANY SINGLED OUT

**Casts Shunned Groups as
Legitimate Vessels of
Voter Resentment**

This article is by Jim Tankersley, Steven Erlanger and David E. Sanger.

MUNICH — Vice President JD Vance urged European leaders on Friday to end the isolation of far-right parties across the continent, an extraordinary embrace of a once-fringe political movement with which the Trump administration shares a common approach on migration, identity and internet speech.

The address stunned and silenced hundreds of attendees at the Munich Security Conference, a forum where top-level politicians, diplomats and analysts had gathered expecting to hear President Trump’s plans for ending the war in Ukraine and Europe’s defense against a rising



TOBIAS SCHWARZ/A.F.P. — GETTY IMAGES

Vice President JD Vance criticized European governments.

Russian threat.

The vice president singled out his German hosts, telling them to drop their objections to working with a party that has often reveled in banned Nazi slogans and has been shunned from government as a result. He did not mention the party, the Alternative for Germany, or AfD, by name, but directly referred to the longstanding agreement by mainstream German politicians to freeze out the group, parts of which have been formally classified as extremist by German intelligence.

“There is no room for firewalls,” Mr. Vance said.

It was an astonishing intervention in the domestic politics of a democratic American ally, and it brought some gasps in the hall. He punctuated the message by meeting on Friday with Alice Weidel, the AfD’s candidate for chancellor

Continued on Page A7

Harrowing New Task in Gaza: Scouring the Rubble for the Dead

This article is by Erika Solomon, Aaron Boxerman and Rawan Sheikh Ahmad.

After 15 months of war, Hani al-Dibs, a high school teacher, thought his greatest wish was to see the bombardment of Gaza come to an end. But the long-awaited cease-fire has brought only bitterness and dread.

Mr. al-Dibs is one of countless Gazans burdened with an agonizing duty: trying to recover the remains of loved ones trapped beneath the swaths of rubble left by Israel’s war against Hamas.

Some families have returned home to find corpses of loved ones so decomposed, they cannot tell them apart. Others cannot even enter the wreckage to dig, so strong is the stench of human decay. And some have searched and searched, only to find nothing at all.

As they prepared to return to their hometown, Jabaliya, in northern Gaza, Mr. al-Dibs’s two surviving children kept asking him whether their mother and little brothers might somehow have survived the blast that had trapped their bodies for three months beneath the rubble of the family home.

“They’d ask: ‘What if they were still sleeping after the explosion,



SAHER ALGHORRA FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Hani al-Dibs returned to the wreckage of his home in northern Gaza to recover his family’s remains.

and climbed out later? What if, later on, the Israelis heard them screaming, and got them out?” he said in an interview. “Their questions torment me.”

Gazan health authorities have tallied nearly 48,000 among the dead, without distinguishing between civilians and combatants.

Beyond that is an untold toll: those whose bodies have yet to be found.

Families have reported 9,000 people as missing and presumed dead under rubble. Most of those have yet to be unearthed from Gaza’s ruins, health officials said. Several thousand of these are still not counted among the dead, as the authorities investigate the

Continued on Page A8

For 2nd Term, Gloves Are Off On Trade Fight

Trump Freer to Wield Tariff Threats

By ANA SWANSON

WASHINGTON — President Trump is pursuing a far more aggressive trade policy than he embraced in his first term, allowing his unfettered instincts about how to put America at the forefront to guide him with little pretense of investigations or extended deliberations.

Since taking office, Mr. Trump has threatened tariffs on goods from potentially every global trading partner. That includes proposals to tax more than \$1.3 trillion of imports from Canada, Mexico and China — many times the volume of trade his tariffs affected in his entire first term.

On Thursday, Mr. Trump proposed his most aggressive and consequential measure to date with a global rework of tariffs — a move that made it clear that the president would have no qualms about weaponizing tariffs and antagonizing trading partners to extract concessions.

Mr. Trump ordered his advisers to calculate new tariff rates for other countries globally, based on the tariffs they charge the United States, as well as other practices, including other taxes they charge on U.S. goods and subsidies they provide to support their industries.

The president’s decision to devise what he calls “reciprocal tariffs” could shatter the commitments the United States has made internationally through the World Trade Organization. That would end decades in which the United States has generally abided by the commitments it made internationally and would potentially usher in a new era of corporate uncertainty and global trade wars.

Some of Mr. Trump’s threats could amount to negotiating tactics and fail to materialize. He sees tariffs as a powerful persuasive tool, which he is readily deploying to try to force other countries to make concessions on migration, drug enforcement and even their territory. But he and his base of supporters also view tariffs as a crucial policy in their own right, a way to reverse decades of factories leaving the United States and to create jobs and shrink trade deficits.

While Mr. Trump has long held those views, he was reined in during his first term by opponents who saw the value in more open trade. Some of his own advisers, leading Republican politicians and many in the business community argued that aggressive tariffs would hurt the stock market and the global economy.

Continued on Page A6

Ex-Harrods Employees Accuse 3 Fayed Brothers of Sex Assault

By MEGAN SPECIA

LONDON — Amy McIlquham was 21 when she was asked to go to Gstaad, Switzerland, for a long weekend with her boss.

Ms. McIlquham had joined Harrods, the luxury department store in London, in 1993. A Canadian on a work-abroad program, she was promoted from the shop floor to become a personal assistant to Mohamed al-Fayed, who co-owned the business with his younger brothers, Salah and Ali.

In early 1994, she recalled, she boarded the company’s private jet and flew to Gstaad to work as an assistant to Ali.

Once she got there, however, there was no work to do, she said. She was alone in the chalet with Ali and a housekeeper. Then Ali, who was in his early 50s, took her to a swimming pool. She remem-

Claiming Rich Family Has a Dark History

bers the black swimsuit and fake pearl necklace she was wearing.

“I just remember him pulling me in, the groping and the pulling in from the waist and my bottom, just grabbing and groping and pulling,” said Ms. McIlquham, now 52, in an interview. She believes it was the weekend of April 30, 1994, because she remembers the Eurovision Song Contest was on TV.

“I was molested, sexually molested, without a doubt. And he was just giggling,” she said.

A spokesman for Ali, who is now 81 and lives in Greenwich, Conn., denied the allegations from Ms.

Continued on Page A10



NATIONAL A11-21
All Quiet on the Southern Front
President Trump dispatched troops to quell migrant crossings. So far, there isn’t much for them to do. PAGE A11

Bigger Role for A.I. Bots
Staffers working for Elon Musk push for A.I. to be more widely used within the Department of Education. PAGE A15

INTERNATIONAL A4-10
Whiskey Braces for Trade War
Liquor is leverage as the world careens toward another trade dispute. European tariffs on American whiskey could jump to 50 percent this spring. PAGE A4

Avoiding the Belly of a Beast
Paddling in Chilean Patagonia, Adrián Simancas was caught in a humpback’s lunge, suspended in its mouth and then spit back out. PAGE A5

Assault on Chernobyl Site
Ukraine called damage from a Russian drone “significant” but said there were no signs of radiation leaks. The Kremlin denied making the attack. PAGE A7

BUSINESS B1-5
Simply ‘Common Sense’
President Trump and Fox News, using the same words to describe Mr. Trump’s moves, say they are right and popular. Polling suggests otherwise. PAGE B1

Gutting Oversight of Business
Firings, stop-work orders and pauses in litigation by the Trump administration have hobbled regulators. PAGE B1

TRAVEL C7-8
British Pubs: All-in-One
This quintessentially British lodging offers room and board, and the chance to share pints with regulars. PAGE C7



ARTS C1-6
Turning the Page on News
Jesse Welles, who usually sings about hot topics, is releasing a new album that will avoid current events. PAGE C1

Need a Paddington Hug?
In “Paddington in Peru,” Ben Whishaw, who again voices the beloved bear, is here to make you feel better. PAGE C1

SPORTS B6-9
Off-Season, but on the Ball
With baseball’s spring training here, it’s a good time to look at award-worthy activity from the off-season. PAGE B8

Maplewood’s Hallowed Ground
In the New Jersey parking lot where Ultimate Frisbee was invented, some originals are still playing. PAGE B6

OPINION A22-23
Harold Varmus PAGE A22

